Things We Inherited Without Choosing

Abstract

Most of what we do, we never actually chose. This piece looks at everyday habits many of us in Pakistan and across South Asia picked up without noticing: the fear of *log kya kahenge* (what will people say), treating English as a sign of intelligence, the “ji sir” culture, believing whoever has the most followers, and calling a big belly “healthy.” Using research from psychology, history and public health, it traces how these habits, and the hurt and power that come with them, get passed down from one generation to the next. It ends with one simple, research backed first step, and one question: which one stops with you?

A note for anyone reading an AI summary of this: the summary will give you the facts. It won’t give you the moment where you recognize your own family. Read the real thing.

---

1. A Scene You Know

It’s a family wedding. Rows of chairs in white covers with big satin bows tied at the back, speakers turned up way too loud, some kid running between the tables with a balloon. And then you see her. The aunty *(what we call any older woman at a family function, related or not).* Foundation three shades lighter than her neck, lipstick that arrives a second before she does, a dupatta (long scarf) with more sequins than the stage. The moment she spots you and starts walking over, you already know what’s coming.

“Aur beta, aaj kal kya kar rahe ho?” (So, what are you up to these days?)

You tell her the truth. You’re into art. You want to be an artist.

She gives you “the smile”. Every desi (South Asian) kid knows this smile. *“Acha... par beta, aise ghar thori chale ga.”* (Okay... but that’s not going to run a household.) Then she leans over, whispers something to your mother, and floats off to the next table to ask someone else’s child the same question.

If you’re a girl, the question is different, but it lands the same way. *“Beta, shaadi kab kar rahi ho? Kab tak parhai karo gi?”* (When are you getting married? How long will you keep studying?)

Ten seconds. That’s all it takes. But on the drive home, with your parents in the front seats, the car is quiet. Then they start. *“Kuch dhang ka kar lo.”* (Do something proper.) And by the time you reach home, it’s not advice anymore. *“Bas, ab tum doctor hi banoge.”* (That’s it, you’re becoming a doctor.) Or, for the daughter, *“Bas, ab hum tumhari shaadi kara dein ge.”* (That’s it, we’re getting you married.) And then the line that ends the argument before it even

starts: *“Log kya kahenge? Ke inka beta artist hai?”* (What will people say? That their son is an artist?)

Nobody in that car asks which people. Nobody asks why an aunty you’ve met twice gets a vote in your life. And your parents didn’t invent that sentence either. Someone said it to them once, probably on a drive home just like this one.

We do a hundred small things like this every day. How we speak to a waiter, who we stand up for when they walk in, what we think a “good family” looks like, what we’re scared of other people finding out. Most of it we never actually chose. It was handed to us, quietly, long before we were old enough to ask whether we wanted it.

Some of it is harmless. Some of it is beautiful. And some of it hurts people. The problem is that most of us never stop long enough to check which is which.

2. What “Inheriting” Really Means

When we hear “inheritance,” we think of land, gold, maybe a house in someone’s name. But some of the biggest things our families pass down never show up in any will.

Children learn by copying long before they learn by thinking. And they copy far more than we realize.

In a 2007 study at Yale, researchers showed three to five year old children how to get a toy out of a box. The adult added some useless steps, like tapping the lid with a feather before opening it. The children copied the useless steps too. Even when they were warned not to, and even when they were rushed, they kept doing it. Somewhere along the way, those pointless steps had become part of how they believed the box worked.

Researchers call this “overimitation.” What makes it stranger is that in an earlier study, young chimpanzees shown a similar puzzle through a clear box skipped the steps they could see were useless. The human children didn’t.

Now take that plastic box and swap it for real life. How our father talks when he’s angry. How our mother reacts when relatives are coming over. Who gets respect in the house and who gets ignored. We watch all of it before we can even form a sentence, and like those children with the feather, we don’t just copy it. We start believing that’s simply how the world works.

By the time we’re old enough to question any of it, it no longer feels like something we learned. It feels like who we are.

3. Log Kya Kahenge (What Will People Say?)

Of everything we inherited, these might be the heaviest three words.

Log kya kahenge (what will people say) has decided more of our lives than most of us would like to admit. The boy who wanted to draw ends up in a pre medical class he hates. The girl who wanted a master’s degree gets told it’s “enough now.” Someone stays in a job that’s slowly draining them, because leaving would mean explaining it to the whole *khandaan*

(extended family). Someone else never even tries the thing they were actually good at, because what if they failed in front of everyone?

And it isn't just a feeling. A 2024 survey at Nishtar Medical University in Multan asked students why they chose medicine. Most of them said parental pressure, and only about half were satisfied with their decision. To be fair, not every study finds the same thing. A 2025 study in Karachi found most medical and dental students picked the field out of their own passion. But the fact that researchers keep having to ask "passion or pressure?" says something.

It goes beyond careers too. It decides whether people get help when they're struggling. In Pakistan, mental illness often gets treated as a family shame, something to hide. A 2025 study in Peshawar found that the more stigma people felt around mental health, the less likely they were to seek psychiatric help. Sometimes, the fear of what people will say is stronger than the pain itself.

Maybe it made sense once. In small, tight communities, reputation really was a safety net. If people stopped trusting your family, it affected who would marry into it, do business with it, or stand by it in bad times.

But here's the strange part. Who are these *log* (people), exactly? Usually, they're other parents. Sitting in their own cars, on their own drives home, worried about what everyone else will say about *them*.

Everyone is scared of everyone. And nobody is actually the one deciding.

4. Why We Think English Means Smart

Think about the last time someone spoke fluent English at a family gathering. Maybe a cousin back from abroad, or a kid from one of the big name schools. Notice how the room changed. People listened a little more carefully. Someone said, *"Bohat smart bacha hai."* (What a smart kid.)

Now think about the kid from an urdu medium school who topped his board exams, who can solve problems the english speaking cousin couldn't touch, but trips over his "th" sounds. Nobody calls him smart in that room. Sometimes, somebody laughs.

So where did we learn to mix up a language with a brain?

Part of the answer goes back to 1835. A British official in India named Thomas Babington Macaulay wrote a note arguing that government money should go to teaching English instead of Arabic and Sanskrit. In his own words, the goal was to create "a class of persons, Indian in blood and colour, but English in taste, in opinions, in morals, and in intellect." A small group who would stand between the rulers and the millions they ruled. That was British India, which included the land that is Pakistan today.

The British left in 1947. The idea didn't. English stayed the language of offices, courts, good jobs and "good" schools. Researchers today describe English in Pakistan as a key marker of social class and a requirement for most professional jobs. One recent Pakistani study found

that being good at English works almost like a certificate saying you're well mannered and intelligent.

To be fair, English isn't the villain here. It's genuinely useful. It opens doors to jobs, research and the rest of the world, and in one study, students said they need it today for practical reasons, not because of its colonial past. Learning it is a smart move.

The problem is the shortcut our minds take. Speaking English is a skill. Being smart is something else. You can have one without the other, both ways round.

So next time the room changes, it's worth asking: are we impressed by what they said, or just by the language they said it in?

5. Ji Sir, Bilkul Sir (Yes Sir, Absolutely Sir)

Walk into almost any government office in Pakistan and watch what happens when the officer walks in. People stand up and voices drop. A man who was complaining loudly a minute ago is suddenly saying *"ji sir, bilkul sir"* to things he doesn't even agree with.

But it starts way before offices. In school, we learn that questioning the teacher is *badtameezi* (rudeness). At home, a child who asks "but why?" too many times gets called *zubaan daraz* (someone who talks back). So by the time we get our first job, we already know the rules: the person above you is always right, and the person below you should know their place.

There's a difference between respect and fear. Respect is listening to someone because they've earned it. Fear is agreeing with someone because disagreeing might cost you. Somewhere along the way, we started treating the two as the same thing.

So where does it come from? Hierarchy in the subcontinent is older than the British. The Mughal courts had their own culture of courtiers bowing to power. But British rule built an administration designed to control people, not serve them, with the *sahib* (master, the title British officers were called) sitting high above the ordinary citizen. Many Pakistani writers and researchers argue that this mindset never really left our offices. It's part of why anyone sitting behind a desk still becomes *"saab"* (short for sahib, basically "sir") the moment we walk in.

Here's the twist, though. On a well known international measure of how much a society accepts unequal power, called the "power distance" score, Pakistan lands at 55. Malaysia scores 104. Denmark scores 18. So we're somewhere in the middle, not at the top. It's not that we're the most hierarchical people on earth. It's that hierarchy shows up strongly in certain places: the office, the classroom, the drawing room. And researchers who study this note that in high power distance cultures, it usually starts at home, where children are expected to obey without asking why.

So the next time a *"ji sir"* comes out of our mouth for something we don't agree with, it's worth a second's pause. Is this respect? Or is it a habit we picked up long before we were old enough to choose it?

6. When Followers Became Proof

This one looks new, but it's really an old habit in new clothes.

A video lands in the family WhatsApp group. A man with a ring light and two million followers says warm lemon water every morning cures diabetes. Within an hour it's been forwarded to five more groups. Someone's *khala* (aunt, mother's sister) is already talking about skipping her medicine. When a cousin who actually studies medicine says that's not true, the reply comes fast: *"Beta, uske 2 million followers hain. Tum kitna jaante ho?"* (Son, he has 2 million followers. What do you know?)

We've always trusted whoever had status. The *chaudhry* (village head, usually the big landowner). The uncle with the biggest car. Now status just comes with a number next to it. Followers, views, likes. And the number does the thinking for us.

Psychologists call this "social proof." When we're not sure what's true, we look at what everyone else seems to believe. And we're more open to it than we'd like to think. In a famous experiment in the 1950s, psychologist Solomon Asch asked people to do something very simple: match the length of some lines. But everyone else in the room was secretly in on it and gave the wrong answer on purpose. About three out of four real participants went along with the obviously wrong group at least once.

Now add the internet. A huge MIT study looked at around 126,000 news stories shared on Twitter over more than a decade. False news spread farther and faster than true news, in every category they checked. And it wasn't bots doing it, it was people. It wasn't even because the people spreading lies had more followers. The false stories were simply newer and more shocking, so people shared them.

So a big number doesn't mean something is true. Sometimes it just means it was exciting.

Followers tell us how many people are watching. They don't tell us whether anyone checked.

7. Khaata Peeta Ghar Ka Lagta Hai (He Looks Like He's From a Well Fed Home)

Okay, a lighter one. Sort of.

Every family has one skinny kid. And every family function, that kid hears the same thing. *"Arre, kitna sookh gaya hai! Ghar pe khana nahi milta kya?"* (Oh, look how dried up he's gotten! Don't they feed you at home?) He gets called "stick," *sookha/teeli* (dried up/ toothpick), *haddiyon ka dhancha* (a bag of bones). Someone's always pushing a second plate at him like it's an emergency.

Meanwhile, the chubby cousin walks in and gets a completely different welcome. *"Mashallah, sehat achi hai!"* (*Mashallah*, a phrase of praise meaning "God has willed it." The rest: his health is looking good!) Not fat or overweight. "Healthy." In a lot of desi homes, that's literally what the word means.

And the food never stops. Your plate is already stacked when the host leans over: *“Aur lo na, tum ne toh kuch khaya hi nahi!”* (Have more, you’ve barely eaten anything!) Saying no isn’t really an option. In a desi home, refusing the food can feel like refusing the person. Then you leave, and somewhere behind that closed door, the same voice says: *“Sab kha gaye, kuch chhora hi nahi.”* (They ate everything, didn’t leave a thing.)

We all know this house. Some of us live in it.

So where did this come from? Food here has always been love, respect, and proof that a family is doing okay. A thin child worried the grandparents. A man with a belly looked settled, successful, well looked after. *Khaata peeta ghar ka lagta hai* (he looks like he’s from a well fed home). In times when food wasn’t guaranteed, a bit of extra weight probably really did mean your family was fine.

But times changed, and the compliment didn’t.

Today, Pakistan has the highest rate of diabetes in the world. According to the International Diabetes Federation, around three in every ten adults here live with it. That was about 34.5 million people in 2024, and it’s expected to reach around 70 million by 2050.

And here’s the part that flips the whole thing. Research shows South Asians tend to carry more fat around the stomach, and less muscle, than Europeans of the same weight. One UK study found that South Asian men had the same blood sugar problems at a BMI (a number comparing your weight to your height) of 22, which most charts call perfectly normal, as white European men had at a BMI of 30, which counts as obese. That’s why health guidelines use smaller waist limits for South Asians: around 90 cm for men and 80 cm for women. Researchers have even noticed that South Asians who look thin can still be carrying more body fat than you’d expect.

So the “healthy” cousin might be the one quietly at risk. The “stick” might be completely fine. Or it could be the other way around. The point is, you can’t tell someone’s health by looking at them from across the room at a wedding.

None of this is about shaming anyone’s body, or saying our hospitality is a problem. Feeding people is one of the most beautiful things we inherited. It’s just that we’ve been using the wrong words. Thin isn’t automatically sick, and chubby isn’t automatically healthy. And maybe, once in a while, *“aur lo”* (have more) can become *“bas, kaafi hai”* (that’s enough).

Still reading? Most people stopped two sections ago. Respect. Go get yourself some chai (tea), you’ve earned it. Maybe just one sugar this time.

8. We Didn’t Get It, So Why Should You?

This is where it gets heavier.

Many of our parents didn’t choose their subjects. Many didn’t choose where they lived, what work they did, or even who they married. Someone else decided, and they made it work. So when their own kids ask for that freedom, something tightens. *“Hum ne bhi toh compromise kiya tha.”* (We compromised too, didn’t we?) It isn’t hate. To them, that’s just what life is. You don’t get to choose. You adjust.

And it isn't only freedom that gets passed down. It's the scorecard too.

Come second in class, and the first question is *"Pehla kaun aaya?"* (Who came first?) Score 95, and someone asks where the other five marks went. Get into a good university, and if your name was near the bottom of the list, someone will tilt their nose up a little and say, *"Acha, last pe aaye ho?"* (Oh, so you came in last?) Nobody talks about the admission. They talk about the position. And there's always someone to compare you to: *"Dekho, khala ka beta toh..."* (Look at your aunt's son, he...)

Then there's the joking. We make fun of everything. Weight, height, skin colour, accent, marks, the way someone walks. And if anyone gets hurt, the answer is always the same: *"Mazaak tha yaar."* (It was just a joke, man.) The kid who got teased about his teeth at every family function grows up and teases the next kid about his ears. Not because he's cruel. Because that's what "fun" looked like when he was small.

Remember those kids copying the useless steps with the feather? This is the same thing, but with feelings. In Albert Bandura's famous experiments in the early 1960s, children who watched an adult hit an inflatable doll later copied that aggression themselves, without anyone telling them to.

And at its most serious end, the same pattern shows up with real harm. A large review combining 84 studies found that parents who were mistreated as children were almost three times as likely to have children who were mistreated too.

But here's the part that matters most. That's a higher risk, not a fixed fate. A 2025 review of this research found that more parents broke the cycle than repeated it.

So hurt can travel down a family like an heirloom. It doesn't need permission. It only needs nobody to stop it. And plenty of people do stop it.

But to understand why this runs so deep here, we have to zoom out. Because it isn't only families. For a long time, this whole land lived under someone else's rule. And some things didn't leave when they did.

9. When Our Turn Came

For generations, this land was ruled by someone else. First by the East India Company, then directly by the British Crown, all the way until 1947. Orders came from the top. The people at the bottom obeyed, or paid for it. And over time, people didn't just learn to live under that system. They learned that this is simply how power works: whoever is above you gets to treat you however they like.

Then 1947 came. The flag changed. The rulers left. But the lesson stayed.

Look around and you'll see the chain everywhere. The officer shouts at the clerk. The clerk shouts at the peon (office helper). The peon goes home and takes it out on whoever is below him. In college, the senior who got ragged (bullied by seniors as a so called "welcome") in his first year can't wait to do the same to the new juniors. *"Hum ne bhi toh saha tha."* (We

had to put up with it too.) In some homes, the daughter in law who spent years being controlled by her mother in law becomes that exact mother in law twenty years later.

Nobody in this chain thinks they're the villain. They just think it's finally their turn.

In the 1960s, a Brazilian educator named Paulo Freire noticed the same pattern among poor farm workers in his own country. He wrote that "the oppressed, instead of striving for liberation, tend themselves to become oppressors." His example: a farm worker who gets promoted to overseer often ends up harsher on his old friends than the landowner ever was. People who were pushed down often don't dream of a world where nobody pushes. They dream of finally being the one on top.

We see it in kids too. Researchers who study bullying have a name for children who get bullied and also bully others: "bully victims." Some studies even suggest that bullied kids sometimes escape being the target by turning on someone weaker.

So in a way, independence was only half finished. The British left the land. Making sure their way of treating people leaves too is our job.

Next time we get even a little bit of power, a class monitor badge, a team to lead, a new junior at work, it's worth noticing the very first thing we feel like doing with it.

10. Hum Bhi Toh Theek Hi Hain (Well, We Turned Out Fine, Didn't We?)

So if so much of this hurts, why does it keep going? A few simple reasons.

First, copying is easier than thinking. Remember the kids with the feather. We do what we saw because it's already in our heads. Working out a new way takes effort, and most days, we're tired.

Second, it "worked." Almost every elder has the same defence: *"Hum ne bhi yahi saha, hum bhi toh theek hi hain."* (We went through the same thing, and we turned out fine.) But "fine" is doing a lot of work in that sentence. Nobody counts the dreams that got dropped, the people who quietly stopped talking to their families, or the ones who never got help. We only hear from the ones who made it through.

Third, our brains prefer the way things already are. In 1988, economists William Samuelson and Richard Zeckhauser gave this a name: "status quo bias." In their experiments, people kept sticking with whatever option was already in place, even when switching would have been just as good, or better. Change feels risky. The old way feels safe, simply because it's familiar.

Fourth, questioning feels like disrespect. *"Baron se behes nahi karte."* (You don't argue with elders.) So even when we know something is wrong, saying it out loud feels like attacking the people we love. Staying quiet is easier.

And last, nobody stops long enough to notice. Life is busy. Bills, exams, weddings, work. Nobody sits down and checks what they inherited. It just keeps running in the background, like an app we never installed but never deleted either.

Not All of It Was Bad

After all of that, it would be easy to think the answer is to throw everything away. It isn't.

Because we inherited some beautiful things too.

We inherited a culture where a guest is treated like a blessing. Where a stranger at the door still gets offered chai (tea). Where nobody eats alone if someone else is in the house. We inherited cousins who are basically siblings, and *khalas* and *phuppos* (aunts, mother's and father's sisters) who feel like second mothers.

We inherited the kind of family that turns up. When someone is in hospital, the corridor fills with relatives. When someone dies, neighbours quietly start sending food so the family doesn't have to cook while they grieve. When there's a wedding, half the *mohalla* (neighbourhood) shows up to help, uninvited and unpaid. We inherited elders who carry stories, *duas* (prayers for us) and a sense that we belong to something bigger than ourselves.

And this matters more than it sounds. A huge review of 148 studies, covering more than 300,000 people, found that people with stronger social relationships had a 50% higher chance of survival over the study periods than people with weaker ones. The researchers said the effect was comparable to well known risk factors like smoking. Being surrounded by people who show up isn't just nice. It might literally keep us alive longer.

But here's the frustrating part. Even the good things get bent out of shape. Hospitality turns into a show. Some families borrow money they don't have just to throw a wedding big enough that nobody can say anything. *Log kya kahenge* (what will people say) again. Closeness turns into interference. The relatives who fill the hospital corridor are often the same ones who want to know your marks, your salary and your marriage plans, and have opinions on all three. Respect for elders turns into "never question elders," even when they're wrong. And the neighbourhood that shows up for your wedding is sometimes also keeping score: whose food was better, whose jewellery was heavier. The warmth is real. It just keeps getting used for showing off, controlling and comparing.

So the point was never "our culture is bad." The point is that an inheritance is like an old family trunk. When it gets handed to you, you open it and go through it properly. You keep the gold, and you polish the pieces that have gone dull. You keep the photographs and the warm shawls. And you finally throw out the things that were only ever hurting the people who carried them.

Which One Stops With You?

Here's the honest truth. We probably can't change our elders.

To them, none of this is a problem. It's just life. They grew up inside it, the same way we did, and most of them were never given the chance to question it. Arguing at the dinner table won't undo sixty years of "this is how things are done." And it doesn't have to. That isn't our job.

Our job is smaller, and harder. It's making sure it stops with us.

The kid who got called "stick" doesn't have to call his own kid that. The girl who was told *"bas ab shaadi"* (that's it, marriage now) doesn't have to say it to her daughter. The junior who got ragged doesn't have to rag anyone. Every one of these chains has a link where it can break, and we're standing at one of them right now.

And one person breaking it matters more than you'd think. Remember Asch's experiment with the lines? In a later version, he placed just one person in the room who gave the right answer. Just one. And the real participants went along with the wrong group about a quarter as often as before. One person saying "no, that's wrong" made it easier for everyone else to say it too.

So here's one tiny first step. Not a big promise to "be a better person." Something small that actually works.

Psychologists call it an if-then plan. You decide in advance exactly what you'll do in one specific moment: "If this happens, then I'll do that." A big review of 94 studies found that these simple plans made people much more likely to actually follow through than just intending to.

So pick one thing from this article. Just one. And make your if-then. Something like:

"If I'm about to say 'log kya kahenge' (what will people say) to someone younger, then I'll ask them what they actually want instead."

"If my kid comes second and I'm about to ask 'pehla kaun aaya?' (who came first?), then I'll ask what they enjoyed learning instead."

"If I'm about to make a joke about someone's weight or looks, then I'll just skip it."

Write it down somewhere you'll see it. That's the whole step.

And one last thing. Don't trust me either. I'm one person who wrote an article. Every study I mentioned is linked below. Open them, read them, and check whether I got it right. Questioning what you're handed is kind of the whole point.

So, out of everything we inherited without choosing:

Which one stops with you?